just wasn’t in our natures. Something in us rebelled against rote-learning and exam-fixation. In short, we felt we had bigger fish to fry and the private means to do it. This lays down another plank in the house of correction for computer hackers: we are arrogant. Compared to policemen, lawyers, army generals and politicians, of course, the computer hacker, you might argue, is a paragon of self-doubt. But we were young and we felt we knew things. That’s for sure. We did feel certain and we did feel abundant in our small way. And arrogance in youth might be counted the budding flower of self-defensiveness.

From early on, the International Subversives wanted to attack military systems, and I invented a program called Sycophant that would run through a computer system harvesting passwords. Each night, through the summer of 1991, we wandered through the corridors of the US Airforce 8th Group Command Headquarters in the Pentagon. We tramped through Motorola in Illinois, padded through Panasonic in New Jersey, tiptoed through Xerox in Palo Alto, and swam down into the twilight lakes of the US Naval Undersea Warfare Engineering Station. There would come a day when people would run revolutions out of their Twitter accounts, and it would feel entirely natural and democratic, but, back then, it was new and totally subversive to feel the pulse of history through a flashing cursor. The journey between the two has been a story of our times.

In the book *Underground: Tales of Hacking, Madness and Obsession from the Electronic Frontier*, my friend, the author Suelette Dreyfus, captures perfectly the scale of ambition that was expressed by our new breed of nerd cognoscenti. And our group, the International Subversives, was going further than any of the others in Australia, further than Phoenix and the other members of The Realm. By the time I was twenty we were attempting to enter the Xanadu of computer networks, the US Department of Defense’s Network Information Centre (NIC) computer. Under my handle, Mendax, I was working most closely with Prime Suspect. Here’s Suelette:

> As both hackers chatted amiably on-line one night, on a Melbourne University computer, Prime Suspect worked quietly in another screen to penetrate ns.nic.ddn.mil, a US Department of Defense system closely linked to NIC. He believed the sister